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KOHLI'S LINE IN THE SAND

With Virat Kohli having quit as Test captain, the juggernaut of Indian cricket threatens to halt



The impact of Virat Kohli's announcement to quit as India's Test captain is akin to the brakes being hit on a speeding train. The screeching sound and the falling passengers create an unsettling effect that takes some time to return to normalcy. Similarly, Indian cricket, too, has been thrown into a tailspin. Not many saw this coming. Having ruled Indian cricket for seven years with a power that seemed unbridled, Kohli, that larger-than life persona, has decided enough is enough. His statement came a day after India suffered a heartbreaking series loss against South Africa, a foe in whose den we had never won a Test series. In Kohli's statement, there was a touch of finality. It reflected his anguish, the pressure he was under, a pressure he seems loath to take on anymore.

In many ways, Kohli's state of mind and bubbling frustration became manifest in his recent, ugly outburst on the field. When the DRS (Decision Review System) overturned the umpire's decision against the South African captain at a crucial stage of the final Test last week, Kohli shouted into the stump mic and accused the host broadcaster of manipulating the ball-tracking system. He had breached a line and ought to have invited a strong reprisal from the cricket establishment. In his long and distinguished career as India captain, Kohli has infused the team with irrepressible energy and boundless enthusiasm. He leads by example, but discretion has never been his strength. As a result, that line of acceptable behaviour has often been crossed.

In executing his plans for the team, a vision that made India a formidable outfit and the world's number one Test team, Kohli had a close ally—former cricketer and television commentator Ravi Shastri. He made no secret of his liking for Shastri, even going to the extent of forcing the Board to remove the legendary Anil Kumble as coach of the team, paving the way for Shastri's recall. And to the credit of both Kohli and Shastri, they did manage to take the Indian team to glorious heights.

Though Kohli's CV as captain was impressive, it did have one lacuna—not winning any ICC trophy. Success in shorter format ICC competitions, including 50-over and 20-over World Cups, had eluded him. This is how the unlimited power of Kohli began to wane. His quitting the T20 captaincy, and subsequently being removed from the 50-over captaincy, resulted in a public spat with the BCCI. But when it came to Test cricket, he remained lord and master. Despite his growing differences with the Board, it is unthinkable that he would have been removed as captain, though the induction of Rahul Dravid as coach was indication enough that his powers were being curtailed.

It is hard to guess what sort of chemistry these two would have developed going forward. The in-your-face aggression that Kohli symbolised is in sharp contrast to Dravid's calm, unflappable nature. It is unlikely that Dravid would have played second fiddle to Kohli's domineering ways and allowed him to control the team like a ringmaster would his circus. One thinks Dravid would have surely squirmed when